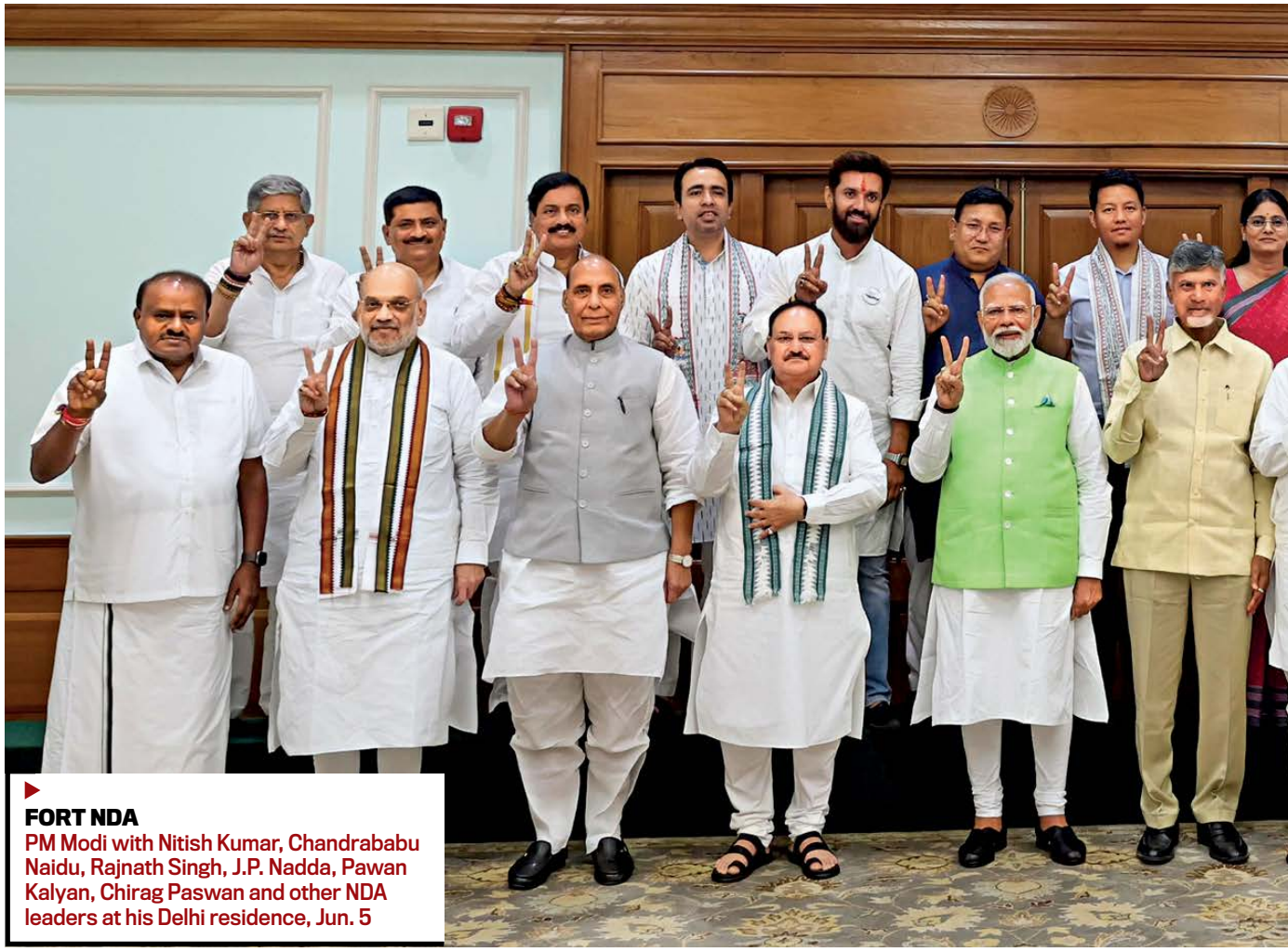


FORT NDA
PM Modi with Nitish Kumar, Chandrababu Naidu, Rajnath Singh, J.P. Nadda, Pawan Kalyan, Chirag Paswan and other NDA leaders at his Delhi residence, Jun. 5

thwarted the BJP's bid to become a united, monolithic pan-national party with a brute majority built around Hindutva. Now, the electorate has strengthened their hand in rejecting the BJP's unitarian agenda and reinforced the belief in India's federal polity that best suits the multiple aspirations of the country's diverse communities, cultures and power structures. That Modi now has to depend on the support of regional leaders like Nitish and Naidu to survive is an indication of regionalism's return to the centre stage of the Indian polity.

COALITION CONTRADICTIONS

The outcome is that Modi, who had a splendid run sans any political constraints in his past two terms, now has to manage the contradictions and compulsions of a coalition government. He will now have to work towards building a consensus across parties if he is to push the needle forward on much-needed economic reforms. That may be a difficult ask of Modi who, as experts point out, has no experience of heading a coalition government, either as the chief minister of Gujarat or as prime minister, accustomed instead to being both a dominating and domineering leader. Though, as a former senior bureaucrat puts it, "Being a PM for so long creates a political osmosis that helps you develop tremendous man management skills. Modi will find it easier to shift gears and modulate his conduct according to the current-day requirements." Sudheendra Kulkarni, a key aide to Atal Bihari Vajpayee when he headed the coalition government between 1998 and 2004, is not so sure. He is sceptical about Modi completing his third term, given that Nitish and Naidu, his two main allies, are unreliable and have ditched him in the past. "After the election," says Kulkarni, "Modi's authority has been considerably reduced, and his legitimacy diminished. He will not be able to push through constitutional amendments of his choice like one nation, one poll. This is the beginning of the end of the Modi era."

There are several intractable issues Modi may find difficult to resolve while dealing with his coalition partners. Nitish, for one, wants the Agniveer scheme reviewed and a national caste census conducted—both moves the BJP is not keen on. Nitish also wants special category status for Bihar (see *Hard Bargain for Central Grants*) to attract more central funds, besides a couple of ministerial berths. Naidu wants the same for his state besides the easing of the many criminal cases against him. The TDP strongman is also likely to go ahead with his commitment to four per cent reservation for Muslims in government jobs in his state, in direct contravention to Modi's opposition to reservations on religious grounds.